

Women in Governance

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

nance ministry extensively with a long stint as Director (Budget), DEA, and later as Additional Secretary, Department of Financial Services, says before the current crop, the ministry had key women functionaries, along with the then Expenditure Secretary Sushma Nath, way back in 2008-09. "At that time, Joint Secretary Budget Loretta Vaz and a lot of officials in the Budget Division were women," she recalls, noting that few women have been posted in crucial roles in the ministry after that.

"These are very demanding posts, and one needs to be on the ball at all times. One needs to read and catch up on contemporary trends and developments, stay late and be prepared to deal with dynamic changes," she says, adding that they also need to navigate these traditional male bastions well.

The Ministry of Corporate Affairs is also headed by a woman, Deepti Gaur Mukherjee, a 1993 batch IAS officer of the Madhya Pradesh cadre. She was appointed to the post in August 2024. She has led the rollout of the flagship Pradhan Mantri Internship Scheme. She has also been instrumental in drafting the amendments to the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Act and is taking forward efforts to scale up Indian professional services firms on the lines of the Global Big Four.

In Mumbai, the country's financial capital, Poonam Gupta is one of the four Deputy Governors of the Reserve Bank of India. She was appointed this April and is the first woman in that role after 14 years. Before her, there have been only three women DGs in the RBI—K.J. Udeshi (2003-2005), Shyamala Gopinath (2004-2009), and Usha Thorat (2005-2010). Since its inception 90 years ago, the RBI has not had a female Governor.

An economist by training, Gupta oversees key portfolios at the RBI, including monetary policy, economic policy and research, financial stability and financial markets and research. Prior to her latest assignment, she headed the Delhi-based economic think tank National Council of Applied Economic Research, where she was appointed Director General in 2021, the first woman to hold that position.

Meanwhile, another woman, T.C.A. Kalyani, is the Controller General of Accounts, in charge of accounting for both the Centre and states.

India's competition regulator, the Competition Commission of India, is also headed by a woman—Ravneet Kaur. Over the past two-and-a-half years, she has shown that she is clearly the person for the job—be it her handling of investigations against Big Tech firms or her work on digital markets and competition.

The National Sample Survey (NSS) is headed Geeta



"Women are a minority in leadership roles and face the consequences of the traditional perception of being soft and not as fierce as men"

INDIRA RAJARAMAN
ECONOMIST AND FORMER
PROFESSOR EMERITUS, NIPFP



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DAKSHITA DAS
FORMER MD AND CEO,
NATIONAL HOUSING BANK

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Singh Rathore. As Director General of NSS, Rathore is leading a nearly 3,000-strong workforce and 5,000 contract workers, who are responsible for collecting and compiling the much-needed data required for policymaking. At present, the NSS is working on 13 surveys. "Providing almost real-time and good quality data are my key priorities," says Rathore.

While it's crucial that the best person is chosen for a job, conversations with women bureaucrats make it clear that their representation in economic portfolios remains thin, especially at the top.

Das points out that this is a challenge not only in the government but also in the private sector, where only a few women rise to the CXO level. "The hope is that this will not be a flash in the pan and more women will continue to be appointed to roles for economic policymaking," she says.

The impressive precedence now set will surely leave a lasting impact in the corridors of power and women will hopefully no longer be seen as the second sex. **BT**

@surabhi_prasad